

A Year in Innovation

As this year draws to a close, information technology finally seems to have found its feet and emerges from the turmoil of the year before, stronger and more mature. Looking back at the best technologies of the year, it is very satisfying to see an upsurge in accessible innovation, defined by sub-Rs 20,000 PCs that can actually do everything reasonably well. The domination of tech-toys has given way to technology that focuses on solving problems and enabling new avenues for work and pleasure.

Who says technology is stagnating? If anything, technology leaders have taken to innovation as a means of catalysing growth. 64-bit hardware is finally here, with two relative dwarfs, Apple and AMD, beating the big guys to the desktop. You won't see the impact of this paradigm shift anytime soon, but it lays the required groundwork for the next year, when we should see richer applications enabled by these processors. With the new push towards wireless and mobility, jacking-in to the network anywhere is a breeze. As the Sony Ericsson P800 and the Handspring Treo 600 converge from opposite corners towards the ultimate connected handheld, it has never been easier to stay connected to the pulse of information and humankind.

The spirit of computing, embodied by versatile, smart appliances, grows beyond the beige box. In their new physical avatars, computers finally present a challenge to the idiot box. While digital music has led the entertainment charge for the last few years, visual media are all set to invade your desktop. Digital cameras may have been beyond the reach of most pockets, but this is the year many Indian brands are planning low-cost 3-megapixel cameras.

Recorded video is another story though. We have been playing hide-n-seek with DVD for 3 years but have yet to see the acceptance of this significantly superior medium. Now that DVD writers are approaching affordability, that might change.

The year ahead may turn out to be the year that the PC firmly establishes itself as the centre of digital everything. For now, we acknowledge the impending transition with the first free movie distributed with a magazine, as a VCD.



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